

Yanyu Li

PhD Speech and Language Sciences, Newcastle University, UK

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Strong background in experimental psycholinguistics and quantitative methods. Particularly interested in cognitive processes related to language processing, attention, and learning. Specifically, my doctoral work investigates the perceptual learning of non-native lexical tones from a cue-weighting approach.

EDUCATION

PhD Speech and Language Sciences, Newcastle University Sep. 2021 – Dec. 2025

- Thesis: An incremental cue-weighting approach to lexical tone training
- Supervisors: Dr. Laurence White and Prof. Ghada Khattab
- Investigated the training effect of incrementally exaggerated acoustic cue in lexical tone perceptual learning.
- Method: Designed 5 experiments on *Gorilla* to explore conditions where perceptual benefits of pitch cue enhancement would sustain. Tonal stimuli were re-synthesised based on speech recordings in Praat. Quantitative data were analysed in R via Generalised Linear Mixed Models through a frequentist approach.

M.A. Linguistics (Distinction), The University of Manchester Sep. 2019 – Dec. 2020

- Key modules: Psycholinguistics, Phonetics and Phonology, Sociolinguistics, Syntax
- Dissertation: Contextual Effect on Second Language Production of Mandarin Tone 2 and Tone 3
Examined contextual effect on L2 Mandarin tone production via experimental reading tasks.
- Acoustic analysis in Praat: normalised tone duration and F0 over large sets of L2 speech recordings. Statistical analysis in R using linear regression models.

B.A. English Literature and Language, Donghua University Sep. 2015 – Jun. 2019

- Dissertation: A study on McDonald's Advertising Discourse from the Perspective of Attitudinal System

Exchange Programme (Outstanding Exchange Student), Lingnan University Jan. – May. 2018

PUBLICATIONS

Journal articles

- Coretta, S., Casillas, J. V., ..., Li, Y., ... & Wood, A. (2023). Multidimensional signals and analytic flexibility: Estimating degrees of freedom in human-speech analyses. *Advances in Methods and Practices in Psychological Science*, 6(3).
- Li, Y., Hoogland, D., Duncan, D. and Zhang, C. "Gamification in phonetic perception data collection: accent identification in North East England" *Linguistics Vanguard*. <https://doi.org/10.1515/lingvan-2025-0184>
- Chen, S., Li, Y., Arche, M.J., Monks, C.P., & White L. (third-round revision, *Studies in Second Language Acquisition*). Teaching Mandarin tones to English speakers via intonational analogy.
- Li, Y., White, L., & Khattab, G. (first-round review, *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition*). The effect of incremental cue training in phonetic learning of lexical tones.
- Li, Y., White, L., & Khattab, G. (in preparation). The effect of incrementally reducing cue exaggeration: an extended training in phonetic learning of lexical tones.

Conference proceedings

- Li, Y., White, L., & Khattab, G. (2023). Incremental cue training: a study of lexical tone learning by non-tonal listeners. In *Proceedings of the 20th International Congress of Phonetic Sciences–ICPhS 2023*.

WORK & ADMINISTRATIVE EXPERIENCE

Work-related

Speech Perception Specialist, University of Tartu

Apr. 2026 – Present

- ERC-funded research project PSG902 “Native Language Experience and the Brain's Perception and Learning of a Foreign Language”.

Research Officer for Human-AI Interaction in Business contexts, University of Essex May. 2026 – Present

- Planning and organising theme-relevant research workshops.

Productive Play House, Text-to-speech linguistic consultant (part-time) Dec. 2025 – Apr. 2026

- Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR) quality check, including correcting speech alignment, transcribing linguistic markers.

Newcastle LingLab manager cover <[link](#)> Jul. 2025 – Sep. 2025

- Co-ordinating with IT or other services online/offline, e.g., for subscriptions or maintenance.
- Ensuring lab setup/access prior to recordings/experiments.

Administration

Newcastle Phonetic and Phonology (P&P) research group student convenor May 2025 – Present

- Updating research website <[link](#)>, e.g., blogs and design.
- Co-ordinating and supporting group meetings, workshops, seminars, and events.

Statistic research group student convenor Mar. 2022 – Present

- Scheduling and leading statistical workshops.

Student school/course representative, Speech and Language Sciences Department Dec. 2022 – Sep. 2024

- Co-ordinated between staff and students to improve research culture and community.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Lecturer: Advanced Statistics, Newcastle University Mar. 2026 – May 2026

- Stage 3 undergraduate module, part of Research Methods.

Tutor: experimental methods related, Newcastle University Sep. 2022 – Dec. 2025

Key modules: Quantitative Data Analysis in R, Phonetics I and II, Language variation & change: dealing with data

- Developed lab materials and led tutorials using relevant tools including R and PRAAT. Marked assignments.

Teaching Assistant, Newcastle University Sep. 2022 – Dec. 2025

Key modules: Phonetics I and II (school of ECLS), Phonetics & Phonology (school of SELLL)

- Provided phonetic ear training of the IPA chart.
- Marked assignments and arranged one-to-one student consultation hours.

Guixue, Language School Jun. 2019 – Aug. 2019

- Developed course content and led 4 modules for IELTS. Improved students' scores on average from 4.5 – 6.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE / MEMBERSHIP

Reviewed journals

- Applied Psycholinguistics

Reviewed conferences

- British Association of Academic Phoneticians Colloquium (BAAP)

Professional membership

- British Academy Early Career Researcher Network Jun. 2026 – Present
- British Association of Academic Phoneticians (BAAP) Sep. 2022 – Present
- Experimental Psychology Society (EPS) Jan. 2026 – Present
- International Speech Communication Association (ISCA) Sep. 2024 – Apr. 2026

RESEARCH & TRAINING EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant in Accent Perception in Higher Education (HE), Newcastle University Apr. 2026 – Present

- Co-designed the investigation and survey of the project “how accent perception shapes your experience at HE”.
- Submitted ethical approval for human data collection.
- Planning and organising relevant workshops to raise awareness of accent discrimination issues in HE.

Collaboration, Newcastle University May. 2023 – Dec. 2024

First author & team lead: Gamification to data collection in sociophonetics

- Identified research objectives, designed experiments, and conducted data analysis.
- Co-ordinated between team members and completed the manuscript as the first author.
- Disseminated outcome in academic conferences and public events.

The 7th & 9th Summer School on Statistical Methods for Linguistics and Psychology (SMLP) Aug. 2025 / Sep. 2022

- Attended workshops on Bayesian analysis and Foundational methods in frequentist statistics.

Speech annotation cross-validation for a PhD colleague

Nov. 2025

- Manual correction for automatically aligned annotation for Italian-English bilingual speech data in Praat.

Research Assistant in Many Speech Analyses <[link](#)>, Newcastle University

Oct. 2021 – Jan. 2023

- Segmented and annotated German speech data from a psycholinguistic experiment in Praat.

Research Assistant in Acoustic Phonetics, Newcastle University

Oct. 2021 – Mar. 2022

- Segmented and annotated dysarthria speech in Praat.

CONFERENCES & TALKS

Invited Talks

- **Gamification to data collection in perceptual dialectology** May. 2026
Northeast Game Network, Newcastle University
- **An incremental cue-based approach to lexical tone learning** Nov. 2025
School of Psychology, Newcastle University
- **Building experiments online: a case study using Gorilla** Apr. 2023
Newcastle Linguistic lab open day, Newcastle University

Conference Presentations

- **International Symposium on Bilingual and L2 Processing in Adults and Children (ISBPAC)** (poster) Jun. 2026
An incremental cue-weighting approach to extended lexical tone training
University of Reading. [Yanyu Li](#), Laurence White, Ghada Khattab
- **Newcastle Brain, Cognition & Behaviour Symposium** (talk) May. 2026
An incremental cue-weighting approach to extended lexical tone training
Newcastle University. [Yanyu Li](#)
- **British Association of Academic Phoneticians (BAAP)** (talk) Apr. 2026
An incremental cue-based approach to extended lexical tone training
Warwick University. [Yanyu Li](#), Laurence White, Ghada Khattab
- **Experimental Psychology Society (EPS) Meeting** (talk) Mar. 2026
An incremental cue-based approach to extended lexical tone training
Newcastle University, [Yanyu Li](#), Laurence White, Ghada Khattab
- **Phonetics and Phonology in Europe (PaPE)** (poster) Jun. 2025
Learning L2 lexical tone discrimination: how is incremental cue training modulated by task difficulty
Palma de Mallorca. [Yanyu Li](#), Laurence White, Ghada Khattab
- **British Association of Academic Phoneticians (BAAP)** (posters) Mar. 2024
Lexical tone learning: the effect of Incremental cue training and tonal experience
Cardiff University. [Yanyu Li](#), Laurence White, Ghada Khattab
Gamifying phonetic data collection
Cardiff University. Cong Zhang, [Yanyu Li](#), Damar Hoogland, Daniel Duncan
- **International Congress of Phonetic Sciences (ICPhS)** (talk) Aug. 2023
Lexical tone learning: the effect of Incremental cue training on non-tonal listeners
Prague. [Yanyu Li](#), Laurence White, Ghada Khattab
- **New Trends in Chinese as a Second Language conference** (talk) Sep. 2023
Lexical tone learning: the effect of Incremental cue training and tonal experience
Lancaster University. [Yanyu Li](#), Laurence White, Ghada Khattab

SELECTED AWARDS

ECLS PGR conference funding, Newcastle University (£500)

Apr. 2026

ECLS PGR conference funding , Newcastle University (£1000)	Jun. 2024
Pioneer Award by Institute of Social Sciences, Newcastle University (£1000)	Jul. 2023
IPA Student Awards by the International Phonetic Association (£600)	Mar. 2023
ECLS PGR conference funding , Newcastle University (£300)	Mar. 2023
PhD Full-Scholarship jointly by Newcastle University and the Chinese Scholarship Council	2021 – 2025
Outstanding Undergraduate Thesis	2019
Scholarship for Undergraduate Exchange Students	2017-2018

VOLUNTARY OUTREACH

HaSS RED programme student orator	Aug. 2025
Discover Festival , Hancock Museum, Newcastle <link>	Jul. 2025
Festival of Social Science , Farrell Centre, Newcastle <link>	Nov. 2024
Coordinated between organisers and the public to disseminate research findings and improve engagement.	
Online host for the seminar <i>Accent and Social Justice</i>	2022
Shanghai International Film Festival	Jun. 2018/2019
Interpreter and Secretary for Stefan Lauding, the President of Warsaw International Film Festival.	
Technology Conference & Exhibition (Hawei Connect)	Oct. 2018
Interpreter for the area <i>Intent-Driven Network</i>.	

RELEVANT SKILLS

- Programming: R, Praat
- Statistical skills: Frequentist/Bayesian mixed-effect regression modelling, factor analysis (e.g., multidimensional scaling), classification analysis (e.g., random forest).
- Other software: LaTeX, Experimental builders (e.g., Gorilla, LabVanced), Word, Excel, PowerPoints
- Languages: Mandarin (native), English (proficient), French (elementary)

REFEREES

- **Laurence White:** Laurence.White@newcastle.ac.uk
Reader in Speech Science, Newcastle University
Relationship: primary PhD supervisor
Address: Room 2.22, Speech and Language Sciences, School of ECLS, King George VI Building NE1 7RU
- **Ghada Khattab:** ghada.khattab@ncl.ac.uk
Professor of Phonetics and Phonology, Newcastle University
Relationship: secondary PhD supervisor
Address: Room 1.06 KGVI, School of ECLS, King George VI Building NE1 7RU
- **Cong Zhang:** Cong.Zhang@newcastle.ac.uk
Lecturer in Phonetics and Phonology, Newcastle University
Relationship: Collaborator & TA-relevant module leader
Address: Room 1.05 KGVI, School of ECLS, King George VI Building NE1 7RU